Assignment: Creative Problem Solving in Storytelling

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Course: Video & Game Pre-Production

Objective

Create:

1. One Short Film Story
2. One Video Game Story

For each story, you must apply all three stages of Creative Problem Solving:

- Problem Definition
- Divergent Thinking
- Convergent Thinking

The final story should be:

- Short and easy to understand
- Commercially appealing (sellable)
- Suitable for modern audiences
- Have clear conflict and emotional stakes
- Demonstrate character growth

Part A: Short Film Story

Step 1: Problem Definition

Basic story idea:

"A young woman receives voice messages from her deceased father after his death."

Identify the story problem.

Ask:

What is missing?

- A clear emotional conflict between the father and daughter before his death
- A strong reason why the voice messages matter beyond nostalgia
- A unique storytelling hook that keeps the audience engaged

Why is the story not engaging?

- The idea of “messages from a dead parent” can feel predictable
- There is no immediate mystery or urgency in the situation
- The emotional payoff is not yet clearly defined

Why should the audience care?

- The audience needs a deeper emotional connection to the father-daughter relationship
- There must be a personal struggle or regret that makes the messages meaningful
- Without tension or discovery, the story feels passive

Problem:
The protagonist receives emotional voice messages from her deceased father, but the story lacks a strong mystery element and emotional conflict, making it feel predictable and less impactful.

Step 2: Divergent Thinking

5 possible solutions.

Example:

What if...

- The father recorded voice messages for future life events before he died?
- The messages slowly reveal a hidden family secret the daughter never knew?
- The daughter initially believes the messages are a prank or hacking incident?
- One of the messages changes her understanding of her father completely?
- The final message can only be unlocked after she makes a life-changing decision?
- The messages guide her through grief, but also force her to confront painful truths?

Do not judge ideas yet.

Step 3: Convergent Thinking

Choose the strongest solution.

Evaluate:

- Which creates the most emotion?
- Which supports the theme?

- Which is realistic to produce?
- Which makes the story memorable?

Choice:
"The father recorded voice messages for future life moments that are unlocked after his death, revealing both love and a hidden truth about their relationship that changes how she sees him forever."

Reason:
This creates emotional depth, a strong mystery element, and a clear character transformation while remaining simple and realistic to film.

💡 **Why this is the strongest:**

- **Emotion:** grief + love + surprise truth
- **Simple to film:** phone + recordings + actress performance
- **Theme strong:** memory, loss, truth, healing
- **Character growth:** daughter changes emotionally
- **Memorable twist:** hidden truth revelation

Final Short Film Story

Title:

Last Message

Genre:

Drama / Emotional Mystery

Logline:

A young woman discovers a series of voice messages left by her late father, each revealing life guidance and a hidden truth that reshapes her understanding of him and herself.

Basic Story Idea:

After her father's death, a young woman begins receiving voice messages he recorded before he passed away. Each message guides her through important moments in life while revealing hidden truths about their family. As she listens, she discovers a deeper connection to her father and to herself.

Story Summary:

After the sudden death of her father, Aira inherits his old phone and unexpectedly discovers a voice message that appears after his passing. The message reveals that her father had prepared a series of scheduled recordings meant to be unlocked at different moments in her future life.

As Aira listens, she hears messages designed for her experiences of failure, love, loss, and success, each offering guidance, comfort, and emotional support as if he is still present in her life.

At first, she feels comforted and emotionally reconnected to him. However, as she continues listening, she notices inconsistencies in his words that do not fully match her memories of their relationship. This creates growing confusion and emotional conflict.

One message hints at a hidden truth behind the emotional distance that existed between them, pushing Aira to question everything she believed about her father.

Unable to wait, she unlocks the final message earlier than intended. In it, her father reveals a painful truth about their past that explains his actions and their strained relationship.

Although the truth is difficult to accept, Aira gradually understands his choices and the love behind them. This realization brings her emotional closure and begins her healing process.

In the end, Aira records her own voice message—not for the past, but for her future self—accepting her emotions and redefining her understanding of love, loss, and forgiveness.

Character Growth (Aira):

- **Beginning:** Aira is grieving, confused, and emotionally distant from the memory of her father.
- **Middle:** The voice messages reveal hidden truths, helping her understand his actions and intentions.
- **End:** She forgives her father, finds emotional closure, and moves forward with greater maturity and self-awareness.

Why the Selected Solution Improved the Story (Last Message):

The selected solution improves the story by turning a simple grief narrative into an emotional mystery. The scheduled voice messages create curiosity, tension, and gradual discovery instead of a predictable storyline.

It also strengthens character development, as Aira actively uncovers the truth about her father while experiencing emotional growth. Each message adds depth and moves the story forward in a structured way.

Overall, the idea makes the story more engaging, emotional, and memorable by combining mystery, strong stakes, and a meaningful resolution.

Part B: Video Game Story

Step 1: Problem Definition

A basic game premise.

“The player must escape a high-tech simulation world.”

Identify the narrative problem.

Ask:

Why should the player care?

- Right now, escaping a simulation is just survival, not emotional motivation.
- There is no personal reason attached to the player’s journey.

What emotional connection exists?

- The player has no identity, no relationships, and no backstory revealed.
- The world feels artificial, so emotional engagement is weak.

Is the mission memorable?

- Escape-based stories are common in games.
- Without a twist or emotional hook, it feels generic and predictable.

Problem:
The objective is clear (escape the simulation), but the story lacks emotional depth, personal stakes, and a meaningful reason for the player to care.

Step 2: Divergent Thinking

5 possible solutions.

Example:

What if...

- The simulation is built from the player's erased memories?
- The AI guiding the player is actually their future self trying to save them?
- Every level restores one lost memory, changing gameplay abilities?
- The player is the creator of the simulation but forgot due to trauma?
- Escaping the simulation reveals a worse real-world truth?
- Another trapped character is someone emotionally connected to the player's past?
- The simulation adapts based on emotional choices, not just skills?

Do not judge ideas yet.

Step 3: Convergent Thinking

Choose the strongest solution.

Evaluate:

- Which provides personal motivation?
- Which supports character development?
- Which improves gameplay progression?

Example Choice:
"The simulation is built from the player's erased memories, and each level restores fragments of their forgotten past."

Reason:
This idea creates strong emotional depth, mystery, and a direct connection between gameplay progression and character identity.

💡 **Why this is the strongest:**

- **Emotion:** Personal journey of self-discovery, loss, and sacrifice.
- **Mystery:** Forgotten memories slowly reveal the truth about the player's past.
- **Theme strong:** Identity, responsibility, truth, and the consequences of one's actions.
- **Character growth:** The player changes from a confused survivor into a self-aware hero.
- **Gameplay integration:** Every level and memory fragment directly advances the story.

- **Memorable twist:** The player discovers they created the simulation and must choose between freedom and humanity's safety.

Final Video Game Story Example

Title:

“Echo Fragments”

Genre:

Sci-Fi / Action Adventure / Mystery

Logline:

A player trapped inside a simulation must recover fragmented memories of their past to discover their true identity and the reason they were erased.

Basic Story Idea (2–3 lines):

A player wakes up inside a mysterious digital simulation with no memory of their identity. To escape, they must collect hidden memory fragments that reveal their forgotten past. As the truth unfolds, they face a life-changing decision that will determine their future.

Story Summary:

The player wakes up inside a broken digital world with no memory of who they are or how they arrived. A system voice activates a mission called “Echo Fragments,” instructing them to escape the simulation.

As the player progresses through different levels, the environment shifts between unstable memory zones such as childhood homes, war-torn cities, and abandoned laboratories. Each stage represents fragments of a forgotten past, slowly revealing emotional truths while unlocking new abilities.

With every completed level, the player regains pieces of their identity and discovers they were once a lead scientist who created the simulation system to protect humanity from a global collapse. However, the experiment went wrong, and the system erased their identity not as punishment, but as a safeguard against a painful truth.

As more memories return, the player realizes that escaping the simulation could reactivate the dangerous system they originally built, putting the real world at risk.

In the final stage, the player faces a critical moral choice: escape and restore reality, risking global destruction, or remain inside the simulation, sacrificing their identity to keep humanity safe.

This final decision defines the ending, emphasizing themes of identity, sacrifice, and responsibility.

Character Growth:

- **Beginning:** The player is confused, lost, and has no memory of their identity or purpose.
- **Middle:** As memories are recovered, the player gains self-awareness and learns the truth about their past actions.
- **End:** The player becomes responsible and selfless, making a difficult choice that prioritizes humanity's safety over personal freedom.

This clearly shows the character arc: **Confusion → Discovery → Sacrifice.**

Why the Selected Solution Improved the Story:

The chosen idea makes the story stronger by adding emotional depth and a personal reason for the journey. Instead of just trying to escape, the player is also trying to discover their true identity, which makes the story more meaningful. It improves character development as the player changes from being confused to understanding their past and purpose. Each level reveals a memory, giving clear progress and keeping the story connected. Overall, it makes the game more emotional, interesting, and memorable.
